campaigned for women's rights, for queer rights. He knew that we all have to be vigilant on behalf of each other when it comes to human rights. Movements like these cannot afford to exist in silos, independent of each other."

The book arrives at a time when the Donald Trump administration has taken several decisions undermining the history of the American Civil Rights Movement. In September 2025, the Trump administration ordered the country's national parks to remove signs, exhibits and artefacts pertaining to slavery, including 'The Scourged Back', an infamous photograph that showed dozens of horrific, criss-crossing scars on an African-American slave's back. The administration also directed governmental agencies to stop hosting

"I THINK THAT WHENEVER HISTORY IS ERASED, IT TAKES US ALL BACK A FEW STEPS COLLECTIVELY," SAYS GANDHI

Black History Month events. The pretexts provided for these decisions are predictably vague—fighting "identity-driven politics" or being "anti-DEI" (diversity, equity and inclusion) and so on—but what is really going on is a systematic erasure of history.

"I think that whenever history is erased, it takes us all back a few steps collectively," says Gandhi. "Not only in America but the world over, there is an attempt to reverse the gains made by social justice movements. And today, you see, the State has such tremendous power over the individual that violent struggle is very likely to be crushed, and crushed quickly. In such a scenario, I want to encourage everybody who sees the value in non-violence." Lawson's life, therefore, he feels, remains very relevant and instructive for everyone, regardless of whether they're an activist or not. ■

—Aditya Mani Jha

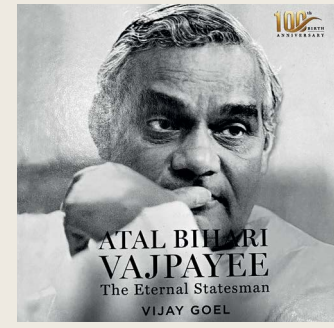
BOOKS ▼

ELOQUENT MEMORY

A CONDENSED ENCOUNTER WITH ONE OF MODERN INDIA'S MOST VENERATED FIGURES

This lovingly curated volume of photographs on Atal Bihari Vajpayee is BJP leader Vijay Goel's photographic *shraddhanjali* to his political mentor. Gleaned from the visual archives of media organisations and photojournalists, the images are mostly 'press images' that are bound by the grammar of public memory, but the author's subjectivity in picking somewhat candid frames—Vajpayee mid-conversation, in the flourish of oratory, in personal silence or caught amidst unguarded laughter—offers a warm glimpse of a figure who transcended political binaries.

The structure and sequencing of the images follows the arc of his life—a young Vajpayee, earnest and sharp-eyed, emerges from the Jana Sangh's ideological crucible. Timeline images wind through his political struggle, the Emergency days, acts of defiance while in opposition, and to the staccato rise in power: From the '13-day government' to the full prime ministership that gave India the Pokhran-II tests, the Lahore Bus Yatra and a political leader who had the halo of statesman and a heart from the hinterland. The 'official' images occasionally reveal a body language of gentle grace, childlike transparency and moments of both hurt and mirth.



ATAL BIHARI VAJPAYEE
The Eternal Statesman
By Vijay Goel
HERITAGE INDIA FOUNDATION
₹4,000; 312 pages





POLITICAL WEIGHT Vajpayee addressing a rally at Ramlila Maidan, New Delhi; (left) serving meals to Bharatiya Jana Sangh workers during its Kanpur session, 1973

This is not just a commemorative volume, but a condensed encounter with one of modern India's most venerated figures. For those who lived through his era, it is a rekindling. For those who did not, it is an introduction that no Wikipedia entry can replicate. ■

—Bandeep Singh